8-WEEK PLAN

Full Body

8 weeks, 3 days.

Days 3 a week **Session** 30–45 min **Equipment** Gym
Version 2026-10-13

What this is

Three sessions a week. Every session trains the whole body: a squat pattern, a hinge pattern, a press, a pull, the shoulders and the trunk. Two sessions, A and B, alternate across the week so that no two workouts in a row are the same. I built this for people whose week is already full. Three days is not a fallback here. It is the right dose for a working adult who wants to get stronger, keep muscle through a fat-loss phase, or come back after time off, and who needs the other four days for the rest of life. Each session is one hard working set per lift after the warm-ups, so the work is short, honest and recoverable. The eight weeks start with a week of finding your loads, build reps on those loads through week four, climb the load through week seven, and end with a re-test against week one so you leave with a number, not a feeling.

Who it's for

- Beginners learning the six movement patterns for the first time
- Anyone whose schedule gives them three training days and no more
- Fat-loss phases, where the goal is to hold muscle while eating less
- Anyone restarting after illness, injury, a new baby or a long layoff
- Shift workers and parents who need a plan that survives a bad week

Who it's not for

- Lifters who can train four or more days a week and want the fastest possible muscle growth
- Anyone trying to bring up one lagging body part. This plan treats the body as a whole

Equipment: a gym with a rack or hack squat, an incline bench, a cable stack with a pulldown, dumbbells and a few machines. Substitutions are listed under every session.

Before you start

Five rules. They are the plan as much as the tables are.

1. The plan is decided before the week starts. Pick your three days on Sunday. Do not decide at 6 pm on a Tuesday whether today is a training day.
2. Weekly averages, never single weigh-ins. Your weight swings two to five pounds a day from water and food. One number is noise. Use the weekly average.
3. A missed day is data, not failure. It tells you what in the plan doesn't fit your life yet.
4. Log every session. The plan works off the record, not off memory.
5. Progress is checked against the record, not against how you feel. A session that felt bad and beat last week's reps is a good session.

Finding your starting loads

There are no fixed weights anywhere in this document. Week 1, session 1 is a load-finding session. For each lift, work up in small jumps until you reach a load you can lift for the bottom of the rep range with two reps left in you. That is your starting load. Write it down. Every later week builds on that number.

If you have to guess between two loads, take the lighter one. A load that is too light in week 1 corrects itself by week 3. A load that is too heavy costs you the whole block.

The warm-up

Five to ten minutes, the same every session.

1. Three to five minutes of easy walking or cycling, enough to raise your temperature
2. Ten bodyweight squats, ten hip hinges with your hands on your hips, ten arm circles each way, ten band pull-aparts or scapular retractions
3. For the first lift of the session, two ramp sets: one at about half the working load for six reps, one at about eighty percent for three reps
4. For every later lift, one ramp set at about seventy percent of the working load for four to five reps

Ramp sets are not working sets. They do not go in the log as work and they never go near failure.

If something hurts in a way that isn't muscle fatigue, stop and see a professional. This plan is not medical advice.

The eight weeks

WEEK	WHAT CHANGES	LOAD RULE	NOTES
1	Load-finding. Sessions A, B, A	Find a load for 8 reps with 2 in reserve on every lift	Log every load. This is the baseline for week 8
2	Sessions B, A, B. Rep target 9	Same loads as week 1	Intermediates take the working set to failure from this week. Beginners keep 2 to 3 in reserve
3	Sessions A, B, A. Rep target 10	Same loads	Rest-pause starts on the four compound lifts for intermediates
4	Sessions B, A, B. Rep target 11	Same loads	Last linear week. If a lift has not moved since week 2, see Troubleshooting
5	Sessions A, B, A. Double progression begins	Work 8 to 12. At 12, add load next session and go back to 8	Big lifts up 5 to 10 lb. Small lifts up 2.5 to 5 lb
6	Sessions B, A, B	Double progression	Same rule. Add load only when the set reaches 12 clean
7	Sessions A, B, A	Double progression	Last building week. Clusters allowed on the lead lift only
8	Sessions B, A, B. Re-test	Last A and last B: repeat week 1 loads, 2 in reserve, log the reps	The difference between week 1 and week 8 is your number

The progression rule in prose

Weeks 1 to 4 are linear. You hold the loads you found in week 1 and the rep target rises by one each week: 8, then 9, then 10, then 11. Intermediates take the single working set to failure and should reach at least the target. If you reach failure below the target two sessions in a row, the week 1 load was too heavy. Drop it five to ten percent and carry on. Beginners stop at the target with two to three reps still in the tank, every set, every week. A beginner never trains to failure on this plan. The nervous system learns the movement faster when every rep is clean.

Weeks 5 to 8 are double progression. Work inside the 8 to 12 range. When the working set reaches 12 reps, at failure for intermediates or with two to three in reserve for beginners, add 5 to 10 lb on the squat, hinge, press and pulldown, 2.5 to 5 lb on the raises and rear delt work, and drop back to 8 reps at the new load. Then climb again. Loads move only when the reps say so.

Week 8 is the re-test. In the last A and the last B of the week, put week 1's loads back on, do the same sets, stop at two reps in reserve exactly as you did in week 1, and log the reps. If you did 8 in week 1 and 13 in week 8, that is your number.

Because A and B alternate, each session type shows up three times over two weeks. The rep target is set by the week, not by the session count. Session A in week 3 has a target of 10 whether it is your first or second A that week.

Deload triggers

Any one of these fires a deload: half the sets, 80 to 90 percent of the load, three to four reps in reserve, no sets to failure, for the rest of that week. Then resume where you were.

- Performance on a key lift drops two sessions in a row
- Five days of feeling flat and heavy
- A week of bad sleep

The sessions

Each session is seven exercises. Intermediates do one working set per exercise after the warm-ups, taken to failure from week 2. Beginners do the labelled alternative in the Notes column: more sets, fewer reps, two to three reps in reserve, no failure. Pick one lane for the whole eight weeks and log which one you are in.

Supersets are marked in the tables. A superset means the two exercises are done back to back with no rest between them, then you rest the stated time before the next pair. One muscle recovers while the other works, so the session gets shorter and the reps often get better. Where a row says "superset with the next row", do that row, move straight to the next, then rest.

Tempo is written as four digits. 3-1-1-0 means three seconds down, a one-second pause at the bottom, one second up, no pause at the top. The three-second lower is where most of the growth stimulus lives. Do not rush it to get more reps.

Session A

Focus: the squat pattern leads, then the incline press and pulldown pair.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Hack squat or Bulgarian split squat	1	8–12	3-1-1-0	3 min	Deep range, pause at the bottom, drive up hard. On the split squat, count reps per leg. Rest-pause from week 3: at failure, rack it, rest 10 to 15 seconds, go again to failure, rest 10 to 15 seconds, go once more. All of that counts as one set. Beginner: 3 sets of 5 to 8, 2 to 3 reps in reserve, 2 min rest, no rest-pause
Incline barbell press	1	8–12	3-0-1-0	0, superset with the next row	Bench at 30 to 45 degrees. Elbows tucked, bar to the upper chest. Three seconds down, press hard. Rest-pause from week 3. Use safety bars or a spotter. Beginner: 3 sets of 8 to 10, 2 to 3 in reserve, dumbbells if there is no spotter
Lat pulldown	1	8–12	3-1-1-0	2–3 min after the pair	V-bar or neutral grip. Pull the elbows down and back, bar to the upper chest, slight lean back. Pause one second at the stretch. Rest-pause from week 3. Beginner: 3 sets of 8 to 10, 2 to 3 in reserve
Romanian deadlift	1	8–12	3-1-1-0	2–3 min	Hinge at the hips with a soft knee. Lower to mid-shin or until the hamstring stretch stops you. Back flat. Pause at the stretch, stand up fast. Rest-pause from week 3. Beginner: 3 sets of 5 to 8, 2 to 3 in reserve, 2 min rest
Dumbbell lateral raise	1	8–12	3-0-1-0	0, superset with the next row	Lead with the elbows, not the hands. Stop at shoulder height. Three seconds down. No swinging. Beginner: 2 sets of 10 to 12, 2 in reserve
Rear delt punch out, cable or machine	1	8–12	3-1-1-0	90 sec after the pair	Pull the handles away from you and turn the hands slightly inward at the end. Stop just before the traps take over. Beginner: 2 sets of 10 to 12, 2 in reserve

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Hanging knee raise or cable crunch	2	10–15	2-1-1-0	60 sec	Curl the pelvis, do not swing the legs. Stop two reps short of failure on both sets, every lane. Beginner: same

Substitutions, Session A

IF THE GYM DOESN'T HAVE	DO THIS INSTEAD, IN THIS ORDER
Hack squat or Bulgarian split squat	Leg press or front squat (machine or barbell), goblet squat (dumbbell), split squat with the rear foot on the floor (bodyweight)
Incline barbell press	Incline machine press, incline dumbbell press, low-to-high cable press, feet-elevated push-up
Lat pulldown	Machine pullover, single-arm dumbbell row with a full stretch at the bottom, straight-arm cable pulldown, pull-ups assisted or weighted
Romanian deadlift	Lying leg curl, dumbbell stiff-leg deadlift, cable pull-through, single-leg hip hinge with bodyweight
Dumbbell lateral raise	Machine lateral raise, keep the dumbbells, cable lateral raise, band lateral raise
Rear delt punch out	Reverse pec deck, bent-over dumbbell lateral raise, face pull, band pull-apart
Hanging knee raise or cable crunch	Machine crunch, dumbbell dead bug, cable crunch, lying leg raise or plank

Session B

Focus: the hinge pattern leads, then the pulldown and incline press pair with the order reversed.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Romanian deadlift or stiff-leg deadlift	1	8–12	3-1-1-0	3 min	This is the lead lift today, so it gets the full ramp. Hinge, soft knee, back flat, pause at the stretch, stand up fast. Rest-pause from week 3. Beginner: 3 sets of 5 to 8, 2 to 3 in reserve, 2 min rest, no rest-pause
Lat pulldown	1	8–12	3-1-1-0	0, superset with the next row	Same cues as Session A. Pull with the elbows. Pause at the stretch. Rest-pause from week 3. Beginner: 3 sets of 8 to 10, 2 to 3 in reserve
Incline dumbbell press	1	8–12	3-0-1-0	2–3 min after the pair	Dumbbells today, barbell on A. Elbows at about 45 degrees to the body. Three seconds down, press hard. Rest-pause from week 3. Beginner: 3 sets of 8 to 10, 2 to 3 in reserve
Bulgarian split squat or hack squat	1	8–12	3-1-1-0	2–3 min	Take the variation you did not do in Session A. Deep, paused, driven. Count reps per leg on the split squat. Rest-pause from week 3. Beginner: 3 sets of 5 to 8, 2 to 3 in reserve, 2 min rest

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
High elbow row, cable or machine	1	8–12	3-1-1-0	2 min	Elbows at or above shoulder height. Pull to the upper chest and pause one second with the shoulder blades together. Stop the pull when the upper back stops contracting, before the traps take over. Beginner: 3 sets of 8 to 10, 2 to 3 in reserve
Dumbbell lateral raise	1	8–12	3-0-1-0	90 sec	Same cues as Session A. Elbows lead, stop at shoulder height, three seconds down. Beginner: 2 sets of 10 to 12, 2 in reserve
Plank or dumbbell dead bug	2	10–15	2-1-1-0	60 sec	On the plank, hold 30 to 45 seconds and count that as one set. On the dead bug, one rep is one arm-and-leg reach. Ribs down, lower back flat on the floor. Beginner: same

Substitutions, Session B

IF THE GYM DOESN'T HAVE	DO THIS INSTEAD, IN THIS ORDER
Romanian deadlift or stiff-leg deadlift	Lying or seated leg curl, dumbbell Romanian deadlift, cable pull-through, single-leg hip hinge with bodyweight
Lat pulldown	Machine pullover, single-arm dumbbell row, straight-arm cable pulldown, pull-ups assisted or weighted
Incline dumbbell press	Incline machine press, flat dumbbell press, low-to-high cable press, feet-elevated push-up
Bulgarian split squat or hack squat	Leg press, goblet squat, no cable version, reverse lunge with bodyweight
High elbow row	Chest-supported machine row, chest-supported dumbbell row, seated cable row with a wide grip, inverted row
Dumbbell lateral raise	Machine lateral raise, keep the dumbbells, cable lateral raise, band lateral raise
Plank or dumbbell dead bug	Machine crunch, dumbbell dead bug, cable crunch, bodyweight dead bug or plank

The week

Session A and Session B alternate. Odd weeks run A, B, A. Even weeks run B, A, B. Over eight weeks you do each session twelve times.

DAY	ODD WEEKS (1, 3, 5, 7)	EVEN WEEKS (2, 4, 6, 8)
Monday	Session A	Session B
Tuesday	Walk	Walk
Wednesday	Session B	Session A
Thursday	Walk	Walk
Friday	Session A	Session B
Saturday	Walk	Walk

DAY	ODD WEEKS (1, 3, 5, 7)	EVEN WEEKS (2, 4, 6, 8)
Sunday	Walk, plan next week	Walk, plan next week

Rolling alternative for shift workers. If your days off move, the rule is one day of rest between sessions and never two sessions back to back. Keep the A, B, A, B order running across the calendar regardless of which day it lands on. Three sessions in any seven days counts as a full week. Two sessions in seven days counts as Plan B.

Session timing

Intermediates: seven exercises, one working set each, with supersets and the stated rests, run 30 to 40 minutes after the warm-up. Beginners: more sets but shorter rests and no rest-pause, 40 to 45 minutes. If a session is running past 50 minutes, the rests are too long or you are talking. Cut the rests to the bottom of the range before you cut an exercise.

Progression and troubleshooting

Adding load

Load goes up only when the reps say so. In weeks 1 to 4 you do not add load at all unless a lift has clearly been set too light: you reach the rep target with four or more reps still in you. If that happens, add one jump next session and keep the target. In weeks 5 to 8 the trigger is 12 clean reps on the working set. Big lifts move 5 to 10 lb. Small lifts move 2.5 to 5 lb. If the gym's smallest jump is bigger than that, hold the load and keep adding reps past 12 until the next jump fits.

A stalled lift

A stall is the same reps at the same load for two sessions of that lift. First, hold the load and work for one more rep on the next two sessions. If that moves, carry on. If two weeks pass with no new rep and no new load, drop the load ten percent and climb back up. Climbing from ten percent down usually takes two weeks and you land above the old stall.

Rest-pause and clusters

Rest-pause is explained in the Session A table and used on the four compound lifts, the squat, the hinge, the press and the pulldown, from week 3 onward for intermediates only. It turns one set into something like three sets of work in under two minutes. Do not use it on the lateral raise, the rear delt work, the row or the trunk work. Those stay as straight sets.

A cluster is a harder version: at failure, rack it, take one deep breath of three to five seconds, go again to failure, and repeat until you have done four short rounds. It is allowed in week 7 only, on the lead lift of the session only, and only if that lift has stalled. It is not a standard tool on this plan. The recovery cost is high and three days a week does not leave room to pay it every session.

A missed session

Slot it in on the next free day with a rest day either side. Never double up. Never do A and B on the same day. If the week is gone, let it go and start the next week on the next scheduled session in the A, B order. Two missed

sessions in one week means the plan is too big for that week. Run Plan B for that week and do not feel bad about it. Plan B is a written part of this program.

Poor sleep

After a night under five hours, cap the session: run the working sets at two to three reps in reserve, no failure, no rest-pause. Keep the loads. Log it as a capped session. One capped session changes nothing. Three in a row is a deload trigger.

When to stop

Muscle burn and the shaking at the end of a hard set are the job. Sharp pain, joint pain or pain that gets worse through the set is not. Stop, swap to a substitution that does not hurt, and if it is still there next session see a professional. This plan is not medical advice.

Cardio and walking

Walking is the conditioning for this plan. Thirty to forty minutes most days, including training days. It can be split into two walks. Outdoors is better than a treadmill for the head, but either counts. On training days, a 15 to 20 minute walk after lifting is the best place for it. Walking recovers you. It does not cost you recovery.

Hard cardio is optional. If you want it, put it on a non-lifting day or after lifting, never before. Twenty minutes is plenty. On a three-day plan the four other days are open, so there is no reason to crowd a lifting day with it.

In a fat-loss phase, walking carries most of the extra energy burn and leaves the strength work untouched. Add walking time before you add hard cardio.

The compliance page

Plan A, the full week

- Three sessions done in the A, B order for that week
- Three sessions logged, every load and every rep
- Protein target hit each day, 1 g per lb of bodyweight as the default line
- Weekly weigh-in average recorded, seven mornings if you can, three at the least
- Walks done, 30 to 40 minutes most days

Plan B, the bare minimum

Life will blow up at least once in eight weeks. When it does, this is a full week:

- Two sessions, one A and one B, in any order, with at least one day between them
- Both logged
- Protein still hit every day
- At least three walks

Two sessions of full-body work keep every pattern trained. Nothing is lost. You pick up the A, B order where it left off the following week. Plan B is not a failed week. It is the second written version of the plan and it counts.

Three questions, every night

- Did I train today, or was it a planned rest day?
- Did I hit protein?
- Did I log it?

Yes or no. Nothing else.

The gate

Eighty percent on the three questions over four weeks means the plan is working. Change nothing before week four.

Week 1 checklist

- Bodyweight Monday morning, fasted, after the bathroom
- Photos: front, side, back, same light, same spot
- Read the whole of week 1 before day 1, including both session tables and the substitutions for your gym
- Put the three session days in a calendar now, with the A or B marked on each
- Pick the Plan B days now, the two you will keep when the week falls apart

---

Discipline without integration is just a faster way to run in the wrong direction.

Stephen Dugger · The Sovereign Method · stephendugger.com · steve@stephendugger.com

Written by Stephen Dugger with help from Claude, an AI model. Every rule in this plan is his.